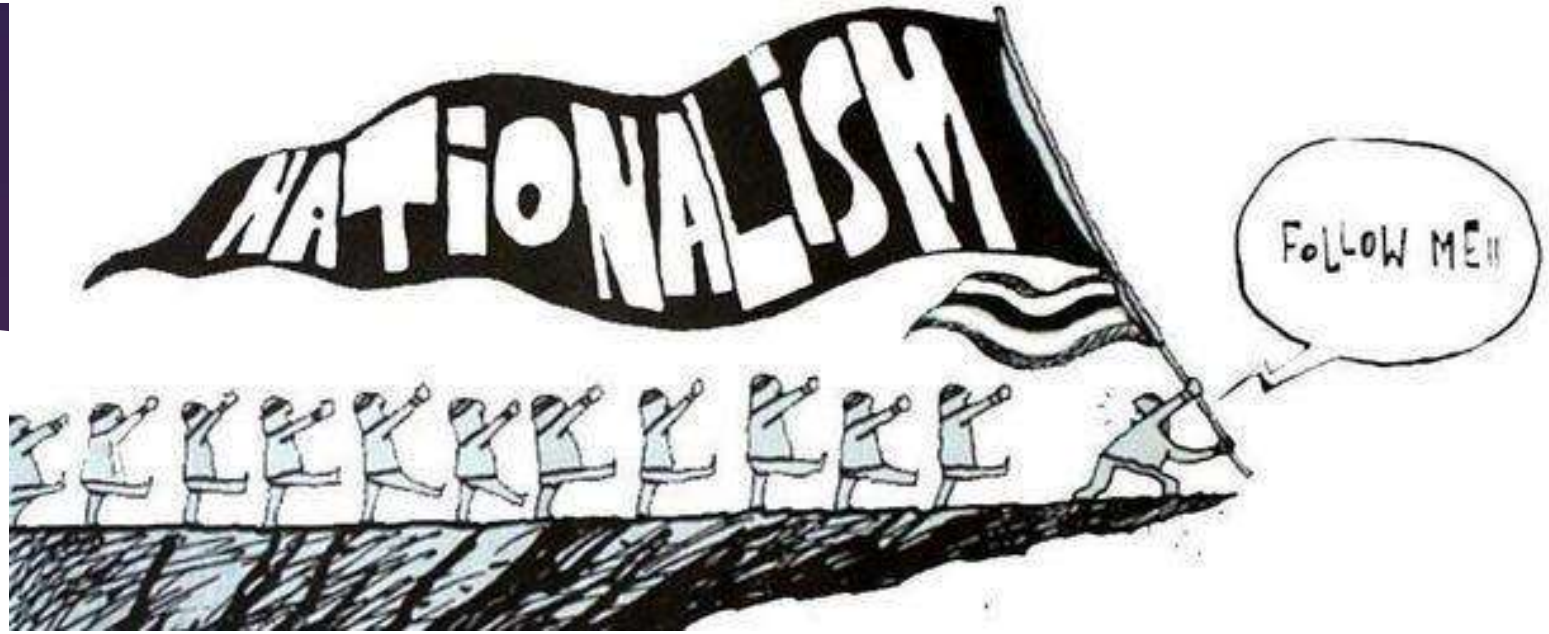
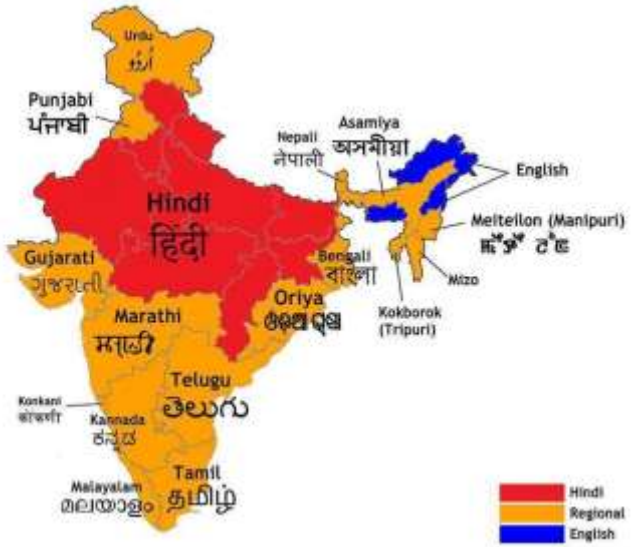
Nationalism



- Rabindranath Tagore in his essay 'Nationalism in India' called Nationalism a menace
- This could be shocking and surprising because nation and nationalism can taken as a natural condition of human political community.
- Therefore, nationalism is unquestionably considered a good thing, the legitimacy of which cannot be questioned.
- Today Nationalism has taken over the control of everyone's minds.
- And that is its success

- Nationalism in India originated in the 19th century and is a historical product of the circumstances created by colonialism.
- In case of the European nationalism also, it is agreed that nations originated in the modem age, mainly in the 18th and 19th centuries.
- In both cases, the emphasis is on the nation being a product of the modern age and a specifically modern political concept.
- Problem arises because the nations like to give themselves their history, tracing their origins back to the remote past.

- In India, interestingly, there was Hindu nationalism as well. A sustained campaign launched by Hindu right wing political and cultural organizations.
- This challenged the legitimacy of the secular nationalism enshrined in the Constitution and also symbolized a crisis of secular nationalism in India.
- So there are two questions
- What form should Indian nationalism take?
- Is the idea of nationalism valid? and whether nationalism creates a desirable political community?



- If a nation is usually defined as a community based on the commonality of culture, language, ethnicity, history and political destiny, then India from the very beginning faced a major problem as it is a land of immense religious, linguistic and cultural diversities.
- Therefore, articulating an idea of Indian nation was a very difficult task from the beginning.

- So who am I? what is my identity?
- This question can be answered by referring to one's language, religion, caste, region, gender, profession, or nationality.
- There are various sources from which a person can derive his/her identity. Many identities can exist in a person at the same time.

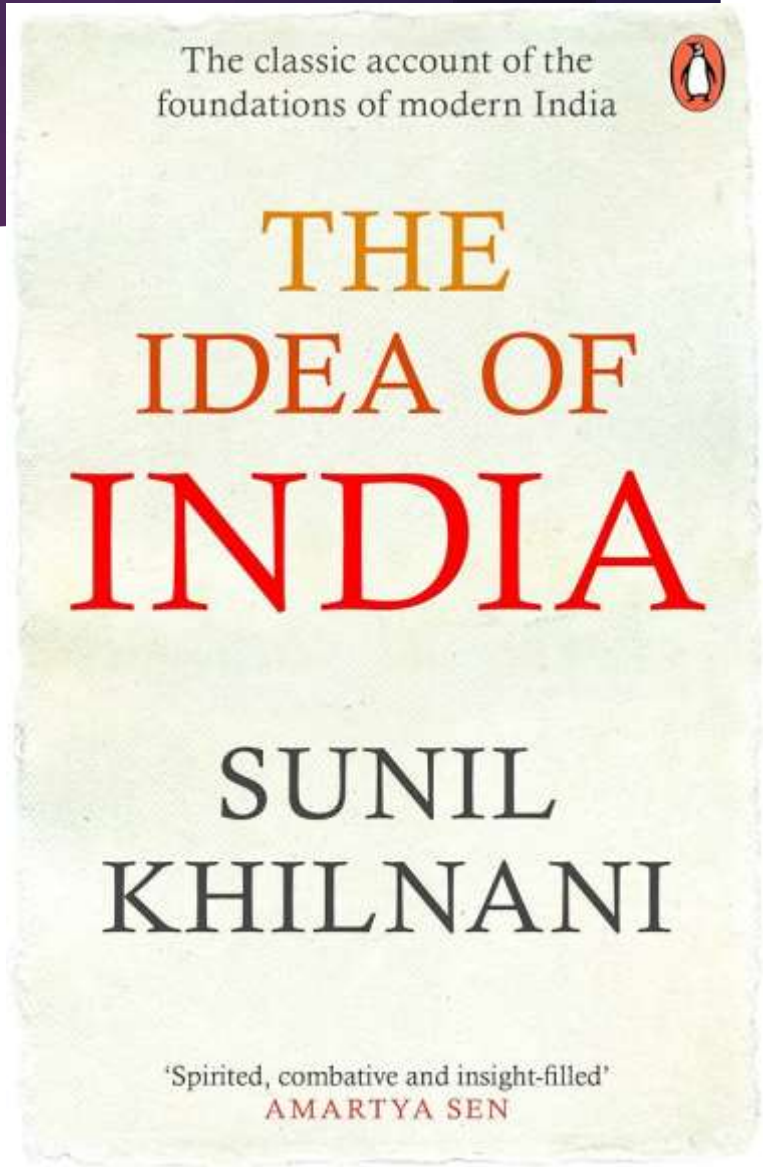
- What does it mean when we say that we are Indians? Does it simply mean that we are citizens of a nation-state called India?
- This is certainly true in a very important sense because the Constitution of India guarantees us this. But the problem with this answer is that it is like saying: 'an Indian is an Indian, who is a citizen of Indian nation-state.'
- However, the nation-state called India came into existence in 1947. But there certainly existed Indian nationalism before 1947 and this nationalism was based on the claim that there existed a nation called India for which Independence from colonial rule was demanded.
- So, is there then any other sense of defining being an 'Indian'?

- A nation is usually defined as a political community with a shared history, culture, and a sense of political goals. By definition, nations are supposed to be culturally homogeneous.
- Historians believe that the idea of a nation, the sense of national identity, and nationalism in India emerged very recently in history, and they are all products of political and cultural response by the English educated middle-class intelligentsia to the colonial rule.

- **Nationalism emerged as a reaction against and as a challenge to colonialism.**

- Sunil Khilnani in his book, The Idea of India, writes:

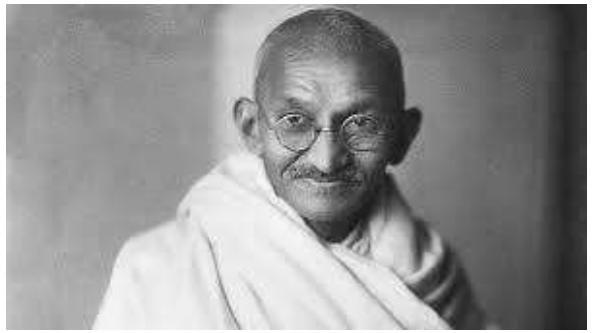
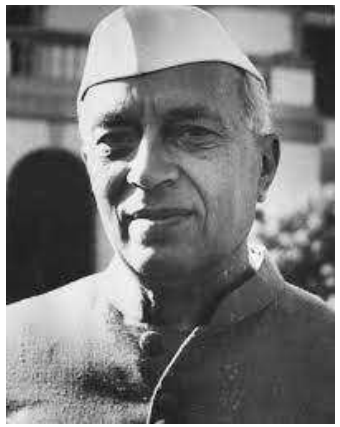
"[After all,] before the nineteenth century, no residents of the subcontinent would have identified themselves as Indian. There existed intricate, ramified vocabularies of common understanding, which classified people by communities of lineage, locality and sect; but "Indian" would not have figured among its terms."



- Earlier, people identified with religion, locality, caste, lineage, etc. because it was possible for them to do that and there was a need for such identities.
- But they could not give themselves the national identity of being an Indian because there was neither the need for such an identity nor was it possible to do so.
- For nationalism to begin, certain form of uniformity was necessary and a sense of purpose.

- The first condition was that the colonial government established a single unified administration for the whole country for an efficient collection of revenue and for effective governance.
- Legal unity by creating a single legal system for the entire British India.
- New means of transport and communication such as the railways, post and telegraph.
- Newspapers and magazines also helped in bringing various regions of British India much closer
- The introduction of English medium education also led to the emergence of a new middle class—the English educated middle class.
- The new education system also brought the educated Indians in contact with the modern political theories like equality, rule of law, self- determination, liberty and above all the idea of nationalism.

- As the leaders of the anti-colonial movement began the task of imagining India as a Nation, there were many possible ways in which India as a nation could be imagined, elaborated, and defined.
- Many competing alternatives also appeared in the course of the freedom struggle and after Independence.
- These alternative perspectives presented different conceptions of nationalism, national history and national culture.

- A nation is understood as a community of people with a shared history.
- The colonial historians, instead, wrote their own history of India. Knowledge of India and its past were an essential part of the project of colonial domination.
- The European historians introduced a tripartite division into the study of Indian history.
- The Indians started writing the history of the country as a reaction against the foreign interpretation of the Indian past.
- But they adopted the same method.
- The most important feature of the 19th century nationalist history writing is they presented the coming of the colonial rule as a boon for the country, as an event that liberates the Hindus from the darkness of the Muslim rule.
- So, in the formative stage of national and historical consciousness in India, the sense of self and identity is based on religion.

- Three periods in the writing of history: beginning (Hindu rule), middle (Muslim rule) and modem (Christian rule) first introduced by the colonial historians of India like James Mill whose History of British India was very influential in the formation of early discourse on history in India.
- The combined effect of all these was that the period of 'Muslim rule' was presented as a time of despotism, misrule and anarchy. They were considered as the foreigner and aggressor.
- So, one strand of nationalism still identifies the history of India with the history of one religion community.
- From the beginning, there has always existed the problem of inclusion and exclusion of various communities into the entity called nation.

- If the shared history and shared culture of the nation is based on the history and culture of one religious community, then the other religious communities get excluded from the membership of the nation;

- If on the other hand, all the religious communities are to have equal stake in the nation and its destiny, then the history and culture of the nation have to be discovered in some other, non-religious or secular way.

Communal Nationalism vs Secular Nationalism

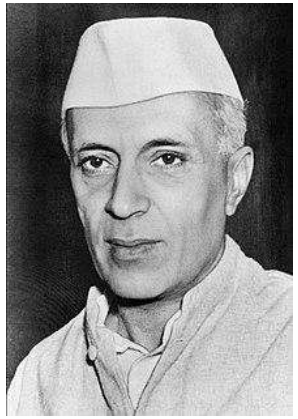
- The politics of communal nationalism has led to many tragic consequences like the Partition of the country in 1947.
- Two versions of communal nationalism were present during the freedom movement: Hindu and Muslim.
- The anti-colonial nationalism in India gained momentum during the Swadeshi movement against the partition of Bengal in 1905.
- During this time, many leaders started to make use of Hindu religious festivals and symbols for the political purpose of mobilizing the masses against colonial rulers.
- The leaders of the swadeshi movement like Bal Gangadhar Tilak and Lala Lajpat Rai popularized the festival of Shivaji Jayanti.
- This interpretation of the Indian history presented historical figures such as Shivaji and Rana Pratap as the heroes of Hindu resistance to the medieval Muslim tyranny.

SHIVAJI
JAYANTI

All India Muslim League

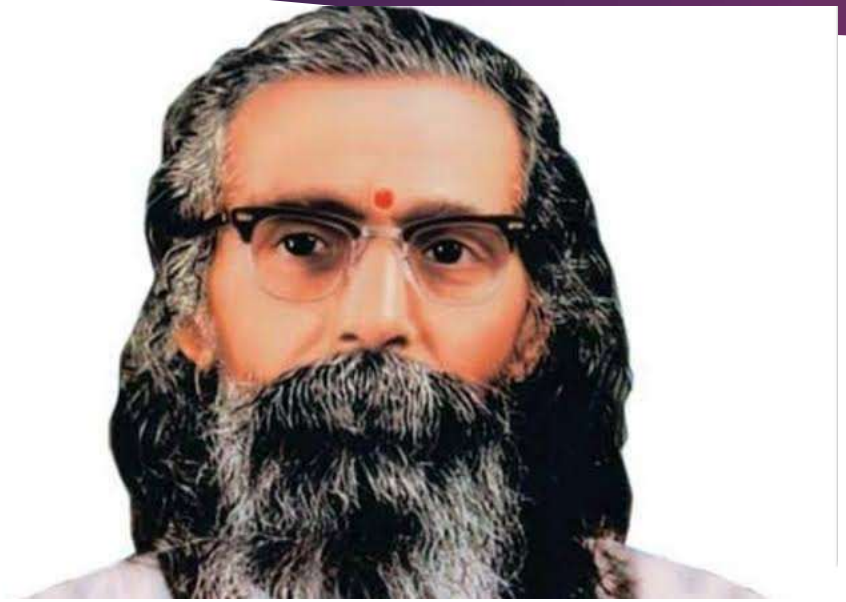
- Meanwhile, a new sense of community identity was developing among the Muslims.
- The Muslims became concerned about some things like the colonial census—which was based on religion as a category of enumeration—and told them of the ‘minority’ status compared with the Hindu ‘majority’.
- Sir Sayyid Ahmed Khan said: The larger community would totally override the interests of the smaller community.
- The nationalism of the Indian National Congress under the leadership of the extremists was alienating the Muslim sections of the population.
- The educated Muslims floated a political party parallel to the Indian National Congress and named it the All Indian Muslim League in December 1906.
- One of the main demands of the Muslim League was separate electorates for the Muslims.

- The Indian National Congress, from its origins, the main political party had tried to present itself as an organization that could represent all groups and communities in India and not merely the majority community of the Hindus.
- The supporters of the Hindu nationalism became more and more marginalized within the Indian National Congress.
- Nehruvian faction imagined Indian nationalism as pluralist and secular.
- By the end of the 1920s three versions of nationalism clearly emerged:
- 1. Hindu nationalism
- 2. Muslim nationalism
- 3. secular nationalism.



- In contemporary India, Hindu nationalism is promoted by organizations like Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), Shiv Sena, Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS), Vishwa Hindu Parishad (VHP) and Bajrang Dal.
- These organizations promote the idea that India is a Hindu nation and the Hindu community should have a more privileged place in this nation than other religious communities.
- Hindu nationalism, promoted by these organizations insists on the acceptance of Hinduness or Hindutva as the essence of Indian nationhood.
- Hindu nationalism in India is based on a communal ideology that identifies nationalism with the promotion and protection of the interests of the Hindu religious community.

- Hindtuva was developed by V. D. Savarkar in his book Hindutva: Who Is a Hindu? and by Golwalkar in We, or Our Nation Defined.
- They elaborate a conception of Indian nationalism based on a specific relationship between territory, history, and culture.
- For Savarkar, only those persons can claim a full membership of the Indian nation who has both his fatherland (pitribhumi) and holy land(punyabhumi) in the territory of India that he broadly equated with the territory of British India.
- Savarkar thus defines a Hindu as 'a person who regards this land of Bharatvarsha from the Indus to the Seas as his pitribhumi as well as punyabhumi that is the cradle land of his religion.'
- Only Hindus, therefore, can be true patriots, not Indian Muslims or Christians with holy lands in Arabia or Palestine.



- Golwalkar
  Savarkar
- We or our Nations defined
  Who is a Hindu?

- Hindus, Sikhs, Jains, and Buddhists can be considered the natural members of the Indian nation as all these religions were born here but not Christians, and Muslims for they do not meet the religious criterion of the holy land within the territory.

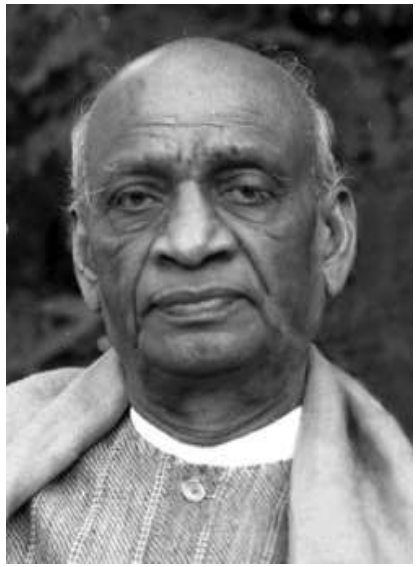
- From this emerges the strong sense of **'Hindu Rashtra'**

Secular Nationalism

- As against communal nationalism, secular nationalism in India is born of a desire to construct an identity of Indian nationhood that recognizes the immense diversity that prevailed in India: the diversities of religion, sect, language, caste, regions etc.

- Its basic idea is the idea of '**unity in diversity**'.

- Mukul Kesavan has argued that the Indian National Congress from its very inception understood itself as a ‘self-consciously representative assembly of Indians from different parts of India.’

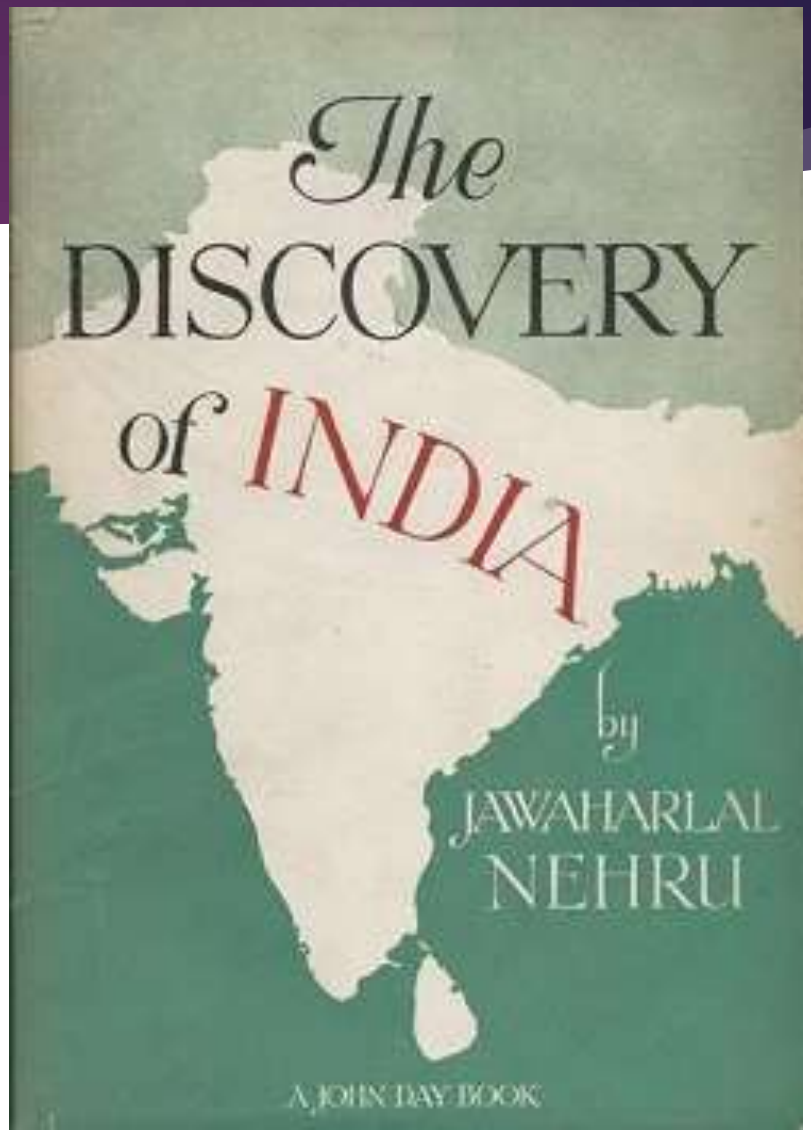


- Yet until 1920s, the Congress leadership did not consciously think about secular nationalism.

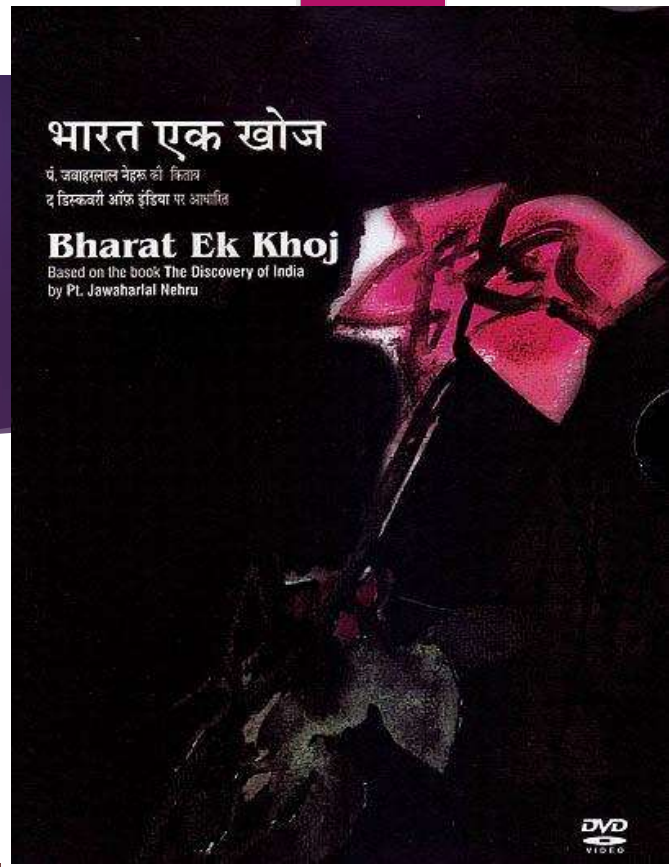
- They tried to form nationalism that was
- Secular meaning anti-communal and
- Recognizing cultural diversity and at the same time having an idea of one common culture

- How to have one common culture?

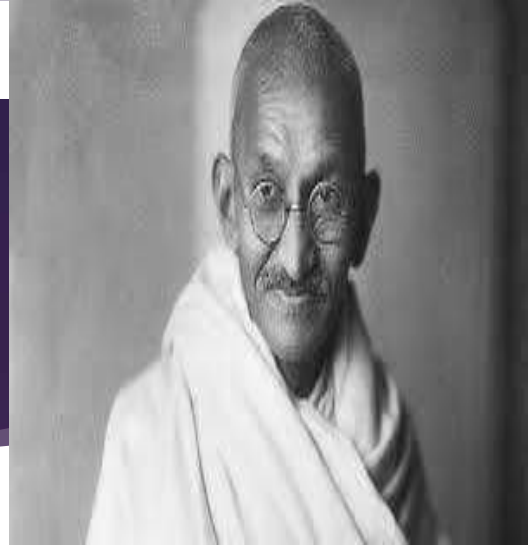
- One such attempt was made by Nehru
- Discovery of India



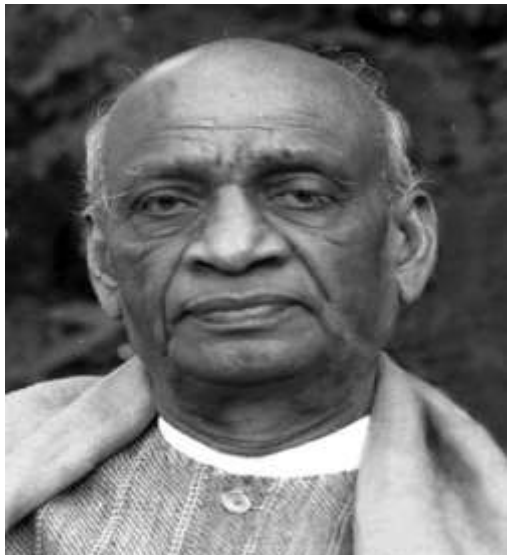
दूरदर्शन
की प्रस्तुति
DOORDARSHAN
presents


भारत एक खोज
पं. जवाहरलाल नेहरू की किताब
द डिस्कवरी ऑफ़ इंडिया पर आधारित
Bharat Ek Khoj
Based on the book The Discovery of India
by Pt. Jawaharlal Nehru
DVD
VIDEO

- In Nehru's Discovery of India, pluralism, syncretism, tolerance, peaceful coexistence, and composite culture appear as the main motifs.
- In this narrative, the heroes of Indian history too are very different figures than those foregrounded in the communal interpretation.
- They are all syncretistic figures: Ashoka, Kabir, Nanak, Akbar, and Gandhi.



Which party will promote whom?
Which icons do you see more often?



- Nehru's view

"Foreign influences poured in and often influenced that culture and were absorbed. Disruptive tendencies gave rise immediately to an attempt to find a synthesis. Some kind of dream of unity has occupied the mind of India since the dawn of civilization. It was something deeper and within its fold, the widest tolerance of belief and custom was practiced and every variety was acknowledged and even encouraged."

Do you think Mughals are outsiders?

- This view was promoted by influential leaders and activists of the Congress Socialist Party and the Communist Party of India.

- This group of politicians also sought to relegate the role of religion to the non-political, private sphere.

- They believed that religion could not play any important role in the political affairs of a modem society.

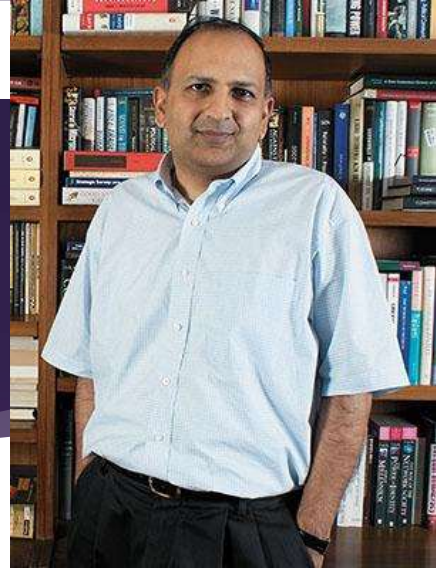
So discuss….should religion play a role?

- During the last two decades of the freedom movement, mainly under the influence of Gandhi and Nehru, a pluralist identity for the Indian nationhood emerged as a strong contender if not the dominant model.

- This stream of politicians promoted the struggle for freedom in India as a struggle for a secular republic where all of India's inhabitants were entitled to live, irrespective of religious denomination.

- The events such as the partition,
- the assassination of Mahatma Gandhi by a communal fanatic, and
- emergence of Nehru as the topmost leader of the Congress and the Prime Minister
- Provided the political background against which the post-Independent Indian State adopted secularism as the principle of State policy.

- Indian idea of secularism was different
- According to Indian secularism if the State had to deal with religious communities, it would deal with them on the basis of symmetry of treatment between different communities.
- It was an idea of secularism based on neutrality and equidistance of State with respect to religious communities.



- Pratap Bhanu Mehta has strongly argued that such a quest for finding a clear cut definition of the Indian identity is indeed not possible without marginalizing, or even putting at risk, some sections of Indians.
- The way out lies in giving up this quest entirely and in looking for ways of acknowledging our differences and in living to learn with these differences in politically acceptable ways.
- In Mehta's words:

Politically what India needs is not a new conception of Indian identity, one that emphasizes pluralism and compositeness. Rather, what we need is a social contract over how we may respect and interact with those with whom we disagree about India's identity. We don t need to ask; what do we share? Rather we need to ask: what are the terms on which we relate to those with whom we disagree? The challenge is not to find what we share; the challenge is to find ways of acknowledging difference.

- Who is an Indian?

The very quest for answering this question in the stronger sense is a trap—an identity trap.